

DUGONG AND MANATEES

A small order of fully aquatic herbivores, sirenians inhabit a range of tropical habitats, from swamps and rivers to marine wetlands and coastal waters.

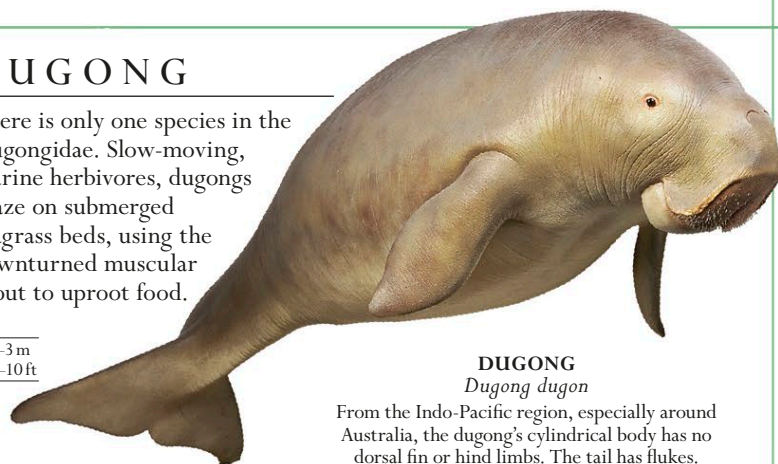
Also known as sea cows, sirenians are supremely adapted to an aquatic way of life. Their front legs are paddle-like and adapted for steering; the hind legs are not visible, being restricted to two small remnant bones floating in the muscle. The body is therefore streamlined, and the flattened tail provides propulsion. A layer of blubber below their skin provides insulation, but to help counteract its natural buoyancy, the bones are dense and the lungs and diaphragm extend for the full length of the spine. The result is a hydrodynamic body, albeit rather slow-moving, capable of fine adjustments to shift its position in the water. All four species are considered to be at risk of extinction.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	SIRENIA
FAMILIES	2
SPECIES	4

DUGONG

There is only one species in the Dugongidae. Slow-moving, marine herbivores, dugongs graze on submerged seagrass beds, using the downturned muscular snout to uproot food.

2.5–3 m
8¼–10 ft



DUGONG
Dugong dugon

From the Indo-Pacific region, especially around Australia, the dugong's cylindrical body has no dorsal fin or hind limbs. The tail has flukes.

MANATEES

With a shorter snout than dugongs, the Trichechidae also differ in the shape of their tail, which is paddle-shaped rather than fluked. Rather sluggish, they spend much of the day sleeping under water, surfacing every 20 minutes to breathe.



AMAZONIAN MANATEE
Trichechus inunguis
A freshwater manatee from the Amazon Basin, this species usually has a characteristic white chest patch.

2–3 m
6½–10 ft



FLORIDA MANATEE
Trichechus manatus latirostris

The largest living sirenian, the Florida manatee inhabits both fresh water and coastal waters of the S.E. USA. It feeds on aquatic plants.

2.5–3.9 m
8–12¾ ft



ANTILLEAN MANATEE
Trichechus manatus manatus

Ranging from Mexico to Brazil, this manatee is smaller and more likely to be found further from the shore than the Florida subspecies.

2.5–3.9 m
8–12¾ ft

HYRAXES

Furry and rotund, modern hyraxes belong to the only extant family in the order Hyracoidea. Hyraxes were once the primary terrestrial herbivores in the Old World. Now just five species remain.

Widely represented in the fossil record of Asia, Africa, and Europe, some extinct species of hyrax were over one metre in height.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	HYRACOIDEA
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	5

Unlike most browsing and grazing animals, hyraxes use their cheek teeth (rather than incisors) to slice vegetation, before chewing it. With a relatively indigestible diet, they have a complex but efficient digestive system in which bacteria break down tough plant matter.

With a number of primitive mammalian features, such as poor control of their internal body temperature, hyraxes show several affinities with elephants: their upper incisor teeth are often extended into short tusks, their soles have sensitive pads, and they have high brain function.

HYRAXES

The Procaviidae are rotund, short-tailed herbivores from Africa and the Middle East. Hyraxes are often seen basking in the sun, and huddling together in groups for warmth. They will also seek shade if too hot. Behaving in this way provides hyraxes with an effective means of thermoregulation.

44–57 cm
17¼–22½ in

long,
silky fur

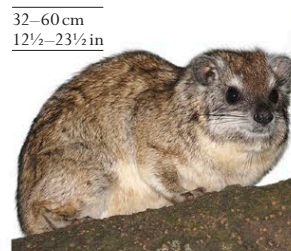


short
snout

WESTERN TREE HYRAX
Dendrohyrax dorsalis

A usually dark, semi-arboreal hyrax from W. and C. Africa, this species has a distinctive white patch on its lower back and rump.

32–56 cm
12½–22 in



SOUTHERN TREE HYRAX
Dendrohyrax arboreus

An able climber from southern Africa, usually inhabiting hollow trees, this hyrax is known for its shrieking territorial calls at night.

39–58 cm
15½–23 in



ROCK HYRAX
Procavia capensis

From Africa and the Middle East, this colonial hyrax basks for long periods. Moist, rubbery foot pads provide grip on smooth rocky surfaces.

BUSH HYRAX
Heterohyrax brucei

There are 24 subspecies of bush hyrax in rocky habitats across Africa. It feeds on grass and fruit, and also catches and eats small vertebrates.